

No Genuine Copula in Japanese: a reanalysis of 'da' as a locative postposition plus a one-argument existential verb¹

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Abstract

This paper proposes a new analysis of the Japanese so-called copula *da* and its non-contracted form *dearu*. Traditionally, it has been regarded as a single copular verb equivalent to English *to be*. However, the separability between *de* and *aru* and the inseparability between NPs and *de* show that this interpretation is inadequate. In sentences such as *kare=wa gakusei dearu* 'he is a student', the noun phrase *gakusei* plus *de* behaves as a single constituent, while *de* and *aru* are separable. This suggests that *gakusei de* forms a postpositional phrase (PP) and that *dearu* should be reanalysed as the locative postposition *de* plus the one-argument existential verb *aru*.

Under this analysis, *kare=wa gakusei dearu* is syntactically an existence-assertive sentence consisting of the ONE-ARGUMENT core clause *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the ADJUNCT *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The non-deletability of the syntactic adjunct *gakusei=de* arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability rather than from syntactic necessity, since *gakusei=de* functions as the focus of the sentence. The paper also accounts for the default negation pattern *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* (partial negation) instead of *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* (total negation), showing that the negator applies to the adjunct domain *gakusei=de* rather than to the existence of *kare* itself.

This reanalysis thus provides a unified account of the structure, semantics and historical development of Japanese *da/dearu* constructions.

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1. Introduction — Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu* and inseparability between NPs and *de*

In Japanese linguistics, *da* and *dearu* have traditionally been treated as a copula equivalent to *to be* in English, as in (1), where *dearu* can be replaced by *=da*, '=' indicating enclisis:

- (1) kare=wa gakusei dearu
he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP
'He is a student.'

However, this analysis faces a major limitation: it cannot account for the **high degree of independence between *de* and *aru* in *dearu***. For example, when the noun *gakusei* 'student' is marked by the focus/additive particle — the so-called *toritatesi* in Japanese — *=mo* 'also', the sentence cannot take the form in (2):

- (2) *kare=wa gakusei =mo **dearu**
he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) also(ADD) COP
'He is also a student.'

but must be as in (3):

- (3) kare=wa gakusei **de** =mo **aru**
he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? also(ADD) COP?
'He is also a student.'

The particle *=mo* is inserted between *de* and *aru*, as if it were an infix. Furthermore, in (4):

- (4) kare=wa gakusei **deari** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP she(SUBJ)=TOP professional(PRED) COP
'He is a student, she is a professional.'

the first *deari* may reduce to *de* alone as in (5):

- (5) kare=wa gakusei **de** kanozyo=wa syakaizin **=da**
he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP? she(SUBJ)=TOP professional(PRED) COP
'He is a student, she is a professional.'

These facts show that ***de* and *aru* are separable**, whereas **the NP *gakusei* and *de* always remain contiguous**, as in (6):

(6) Kare=*wa* gakusei de aru.

Kare=*wa* gakusei de mo aru.

Kare=*wa* gakusei de, kanozyo=*wa* syakaizin=*da*.

Hence, in *kare=wa gakusei dearu*, the sequence *gakusei* plus *de* is assumed to constitute a single inseparable constituent, as Dalla Chiesa (2015) notes: "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase". This *gakusei de* is formally identical to a **postpositional phrase (PP) consisting of a NP + the postposition =de**. In what follows, therefore, *gakusei de* will be treated as a PP, that is, PP *gakusei=de*. This separation between *=de* and *aru* is compatible with Matsuoka's observation that "the copula *da* consists of the postposition *de* and the verb *aru*" (2019: 142).

2. NP + =de as a locative adjunct PP and the one-argument existential verb *aru*

In Japanese, PPs of the form "NP + =de" function generally as adjuncts. Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is assumed to consist syntactically of a **mandatory structure** [*kare=wa aru*] and an **adjunct structure** [*gakusei=de*].

In *kare=wa aru*, the predicate *aru* — or, more precisely, its stem *ar-* — can thus be analysed as a **ONE-ARGUMENT verb**, taking only the NP *kare* as its argument. When the verb *aru* **functions as one-argument predicate, it means 'to exist'** — though rather literary, as in *ware omou, yueni ware ari* 'I think, therefore I am' — and the sentence *kare=wa aru* can thus be interpreted as 'he exists', **asserting the existence** of *kare*. As for the PP *gakusei=de*, on the other hand, although **PPs headed by =de** can express a variety of semantic roles such as location, means or cause, in this case it can be interpreted as neither means nor cause. The most plausible interpretation is therefore **locative** — not a physical but a **conceptual location**.

Consequently, *gakusei=de* means 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The entire structure *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is thus, syntactically, composed of **the mandatory ONE-ARGUMENT clause** [*kare wa aru*] 'he exists' and **the ADJUNCT** [*gakusei=de*] 'in the conceptual domain "student"'. Semantically, it expresses 'He exists, and the location of his existence is the conceptual domain of "student"' or, more simply, 'He exists, and it is as a student'. Schematically, *A=wa B=de aru* can be represented as **E(A) $\wedge$ IN(A, B)**, where E(A) — E abbreviates EXIST — denotes the **assertion of existence** and IN(A, B) the **specification of**

the domain of existence.

Thus, in place of the traditional **copula-based** analysis in (7) = (1):

- (7) kare=wa gakusei dear-u
he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED) COP-PRES
'He is a student.'

in this paper, a one-argument-existential-verb-based analysis is adopted, as in (8), where CONCEPT-LOC abbreviates 'conceptual-locative':

- (8) kare=wa gakusei=de ar-u
he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
'He exists, and it is as a student.'

3. The difference between *kare wa gakusei=DE ARu* and *sore wa gakkō=NI ARu*

In contrast to the construction *sore=wa gakkō=de aru* in (9) = (8), hypothesised as **existence-assertive** in Section 2:

- (9) sore=wa gakkō=**de** ar-u
it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEPT-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
'It exists, and it is as a school.'

in genuine **locative** constructions as in (10) and (11), where PHYSIC-LOC abbreviates 'physical-locative':

- (10) sore=wa gakkō=**ni** ar-u
it(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
'It is in the school.'
- (11) kare=wa gakkō=**ni** i-ru
he(SUBJ)=TOP school=PHYSIC-LOC(ARGUMENT) be located-PRES
'He is in the school.'

the **locative argument is obligatory and always marked by the postposition =ni, rather than =de**. The formal difference between (9) and (10) further supports the above analysis. The verb *aru* — more precisely, its stem *ar-* — when used as a **LOCATIVE verb**, is a **TWO-ARGUMENT predicate with the argument structure [location, theme]**, the location being denoted by the postpositional phrase [NP + =ni], as in *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru*. When the theme is animate, the verb *iru* with the stem *i-* is used instead, with the argument PP [NP + =ni]

unchanged, as in *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school', whereas the ungrammatical sentence in (12) which employs the PP [NP + =de]:

- (12) *kare=wa gakkō=de i-ru*
 he(SUBJ)=TOP school=LOC(ADJUNCT) ?-PRES
 ' ? '

is not semantically interpretable — even for native speakers — and ungrammatical.

Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* should be regarded SYNTACTICALLY — though NOT PRAGMATICALLY OR INFORMATIONALLY, as will be discussed in Section 4 — as a **structurally self-contained existence-assertive clause** *kare=wa aru* 'he exists', **accompanied by the locative adjunct** *gakusei=de*, **which specifies the domain of existence**.

4. The syntactic optionality and pragmatic necessity of *gakusei=de*

Although *gakusei=de* in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is **syntactically an adjunct**, it **cannot be deleted**. This is because the sentence, while structurally consisting of the mandatory core *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or 'as a student', serves as a **presentational sentence** in which **the focus is domaind on the adjunct** *gakusei=de*.

Therefore, the **non-deletability of *gakusei=de*** arises from its **pragmatic and informational indispensability** rather than from syntactic necessity. The distinction can be represented as follows:

Level	Structure	Function
Syntax	[NP <i>A ar-</i>] + [PP <i>B=de</i>]	One-argument predicate + adjunct
Semantics	"A exists, and it is in the domain B"	Existence assertion + its domain restriction
Information Structure	[<i>A=wa aru</i>] + [<i>B=de</i>]	Given + New (default)
Pragmatics	Focus on <i>B=de</i> (default)	Pragmatic obligatoriness and non-deletability of <i>B=de</i> due to focus

5. Old Japanese forms

In Old Japanese, the modern *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* would correspond to *kare gakusei nari*, derived from *kare gakusei=ni ari*. Before the emergence of the postposition-suffix sequence *=nite*, the postposition *=ni* could mark both arguments and adjuncts. Thus, *kare gakusei=ni ari* can be analysed as consisting of the one-argument core clause *kare ari* 'he exists' and the locative adjunct *gakusei=ni* 'in the conceptual domain denoted by *gakusei*', as indicated in (13), which is consistent with the present hypothesis:

- (13) *kare* *gakusei=ni* *ari-0*
it(SUBJ)=TOP school=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The subsequent development *kare gakusei=n-ari* → *kare gakusei=nite ari* → *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* reflects the diachronic split between *=ni*, used for arguments, and *=nite*, used for adjuncts. This may represent a shift from a linguistic stage in which *=ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which *=ni* and *=nite* became specialised as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively — a possibility that requires further historical investigation.

6. Scope of negation denoted by the particle *=wa*

Negation in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* 'he exists, and it is as a student' in (14) = (8):

- (14) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* *ar-u*
he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist-PRES
'He exists, and it is as a student.'

DEFAULTLY appears as *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* 'he exists, but it is **not** as a student' (partial negation) — underlyingly, **kare=wa gakusei=de=wa ara-nai*, since in contemporary Standard Japanese the negative form of the verb *aru* is not the theoretically expected **ara-nai*, but obligatorily the suppletive verbal adjective *nai* — ai in (15):

- (15) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de=wa* (*ara) *nai-0*
he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT)=SCOPE OF NEGATION exist NEG-PRES
'He exists, but it is not as a student.'

rather than *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* 'he does **not** exist as a student' (total negation) —

underlyingly, **kare=wa gakusei=de ara-nai*, as in (16):

- (16) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* (**ara*) **nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) exist NEG-PRES
 'He does not exists as a student.'

This is because the sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* does **not negate the existence of *kare* itself**, but rather **negates *gakusei=de* as the domain of existence**, since in Japanese **the particle =wa can mark the scope of negation**, as in (15).

Schematically, the partial negation *A=wa B=de=wa nai* — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de=wa ara-nai* — can be represented as $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, in line with Section 2, whereas the total negation *A=wa B=de nai* — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de ara-nai* — can be represented as $\neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$, that is, $\neg E(A) \vee \neg IN(A, B)$. Although this condition is compatible with $\neg E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$ or $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, the first case is inconsistent given the semantic postulate $IN(A, B) \Rightarrow E(A)$ — hence $\neg E(A) \Rightarrow \neg IN(A, B)$ — and the option $\neg E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B) = \neg E(A)$ — namely, the third case — is pragmatically infelicitous in topicalised clauses with *A=wa*, since *A=wa*, as a topic phrase, tends to presuppose the discourse-givenness or existence of A and there are dedicated Japanese forms for existential negation such as *A wa inai/nai*; therefore, in practice the interpretation converges on $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Hence the former pattern, which unambiguously denotes $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, is judged to be the more natural one.

If *=de aru* were a single copula, then *A=wa B=de aru* would denote $BE(A, B)$, and its negation would be plain predicate negation — namely, *A=wa B=de nai*, represented as $\neg BE(A, B)$, with no *=wa* after *=de*. **Empirically, nevertheless, *A=wa B=de nai* is felt to be infelicitous, whereas *A=wa B=de=wa nai* is preferred.** This obligatory *=wa* on *=de* is unexpected under the simple-copula analysis, but follows immediately if the clause decomposes as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ and the intended reading is the partial negation $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Furthermore, if *=de aru* were a single copular unit, partial negation with *=wa* would necessarily take the form **kare=wa gakusei=wa de nai*, as in (17):

- (17) **kare=wa* *gakusei=wa* *de* **nai-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student(PRED)=SCOPE OF NEGATION COP NEG-PRES
 'He is not a student, but something else.'

The fact that this is ungrammatical further supports the separability of *=de* and *aru* and the adjunctive nature of *gakusei=de*.

7. The contracted form *=da*

In spoken language, the contracted form *=da* is often used instead of *=de aru*, which is more formal and literal, as in *kare=wa gakusei=**da*** 'he is a student'. It should be noted that this **contracted form *=da*** does not represent a new copular category but a **purely phonological reduction of the postpositional-verbal complex *=de aru***, as shown in (18):

- (18) *kare=wa* *gakusei=**d*** **a-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=CONCEP-LOC(ADJUNCT) **exist-PRES**
 'He exists, and it is as a student.'

The historical change from *=de aru* to *=da*, possibly via *=dea*², involves no syntactic or semantic reanalysis, but only a process of phonetic contraction comparable to French *à le* → *au* 'to the' or Portuguese *de a* → *da* 'from the, of the'. Just as there is no semantic necessity for *à* and *le* to fuse into *au*, or for *de* and *a* into *da* — a phenomenon comparable to the English *to the* or *from the* forming a single word — there is likewise no semantic motivation for *=de* and *aru* to form a single lexical item.

The two elements remain distinct in their underlying structure: *=de* functions as a postposition indicating the domain in which existence holds, and the stem of *aru* as the existential verb itself. This is precisely why the following colloquial dialogue is possible:

*Kare=tte gakusei=**da** yone?* — *Iya, gakusei=tte yū=ka, gakusei=**de=mo aru**=tte kanzi kana.*

'He's a student, right?' — 'Well, if you can call him a student, I'd say he's *also* a student, kind of.'

In this dialogue, the interlocutor, recognising that the underlying structure of *gakusei=da* is *gakusei=de aru*, when asked to confirm that *kare*'s domain of existence can be identified as that of 'student', replies that his existence extends to other domains as well, expressed by the form

² Historically, the form *=dea*, which yielded the modern *=da*, can be attested in Azuchi–Momoyama-period materials: *bonnin yorimo giūzaini fuxōzuru cotodea* '(it) is a reason for imposing a heavier guilt (on him) than on an ordinary person' (Amakusa Edition of *Esopo no fabulas*, 1593, p.475, ll.10-11, in Text Data Sets for Research on the History of Japanese).

gakusei=de=mo aru.

Returning to Section 1, *kare=wa gakusei=de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=da* 'he (is) a student, and she is a professional' is thus, underlyingly, a compound sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de ari, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=de aru*, in which the first predicate *ari* is deleted as recoverable, on the basis of the structural parallelism between the two coordinate clauses, as indicated in (19):

- (19) *kare=wa* *gakusei=de* (**ari**) *kanozyo=wa* *syakaizin=d* **a-0**
 he(SUBJ)=TOP student=LOC(ADJT) (**exist**) she(SUBJ)=TOP professional=LOC(ADJT) **exist-PRES**
 'He (**exists**) as a student, she **exists** as a professional.'

Therefore, *=da* as a whole should not be regarded as a copula in the strict sense, but as a **phonologically reduced surface realisation of the underlying construction *=de aru*** (more theoretically, *=de ar-0*, where *ar-* and *-0* represent the stem of the existential verb *aru* and a phonologically zero tense suffix specified as [–past]).

8. Conclusion — *dearu* not as a copula but as the postposition *=de* followed by the existential verb *aru* and *da* as its contracted form

To summarise, the syntactic structure of *A=wa B dearu* 'A is B' consists of a **mandatory existence-assertive clause** [*A=wa aru*] '**A exists**' and an **adjunctive phrase** [*B=de*] '**in the conceptual domain denoted by B' or 'as B'**'. It should therefore be syntactically represented as *A=wa B=de aru*. Consequently, treating *dearu* or its contracted form *da* as a single copula is structurally problematic. The form *dearu* is more appropriately analysed as an **existence-domain complex**, composed of the existential verb *aru* and the postpositional phrase *B=de*, which specifies the domain in which the existence of *A* is realised. The more colloquial form *=da* is a phonologically contracted form corresponding to the more formal and literal *=de aru*.

Thus, through the above syntactic analysis, it has been possible to account, by means of a single, consistent principle — namely, the **assertion of existence by [NP₁ + *aru*]** and the **specification of the domain of existence by [NP₂ + *=de*]**, schematically represented by **E(NP₁) ∧ IN(NP₁, NP₂)** — for:

- Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu*
- Inseparability between NPs and *de*

- Optional omission of *aru* in *dearu*
- Historical development $A\ B=\textit{ni}\ ari \rightarrow A\ B=\textit{nari} \rightarrow A\ B=\textit{nite}\ ari \rightarrow A=\textit{wa}\ B=\textit{de}\ aru$
- Ground on which the **default negation** of $A=\textit{wa}\ B=\textit{de}\ aru$ is not the total $A=\textit{wa}\ B=\textit{de}\ \textit{nai}$ but the **partial** $A=\textit{wa}\ B=\textit{de}=\textit{wa}\ \textit{nai}$
- Underlying structure of $=\textit{da}$ as $=\textit{de}\ aru$

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